



BE READY.

Before the season

Pre-season: the guide

How your program works: schedule, how the sessions run, progression and the rules to know.

Duration

8 weeks

Frequency

3 sessions + 1 bonus

Session

45 to 60 min

Place

Gym

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Before you start

8 weeks to build solid foundations before training restarts with your club. This guide explains how your program works.

When to start?

Do your program during the **2 months before the season starts**: usually July and August, for a season that begins in early September.

Your club	Weeks 1 to 4	Weeks 5 to 8
Runs physical preparation when training restarts (for example in early August)	On your own, before your club restarts	Alongside your club's physical preparation sessions
Runs no physical preparation	On your own, from early July	On your own, until the season starts

Alongside your club: keep 48 hours between two A, B or C sessions, no session the day before a very intense team practice, and ease off (fewer sets) if fatigue builds up. Start your access to the animations on the day of your first session.

You received	What it is for
This guide	Understanding the program: how it works, schedule, progression, rules
Your sessions	All your sessions written out in full, in order, with the warm-up, your goal or goals, core work, the cool-down and an illustrated sheet for every exercise
Running option (if chosen)	Your extra running sessions

On training day, all you need is the "Your sessions" document: everything is in it, from the warm-up to the cool-down. This guide is for understanding the program: read it once in full before you start.

Equipment

Your program is built for the gym: dumbbells, barbell, bench, cables, plyo box, medicine ball. For running, use a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself) if your gym has one; otherwise each sheet gives an alternative (assault bike, rowing machine).

Choosing your level

Level	Who it is for	In the sessions
Level 1	You are a beginner: little or no physical preparation so far	Lowest number of sets, "easier" versions
Level 2	You have some foundations: a season of strength training or physical preparation	Middle number of sets
Level 3	You are experienced: several seasons of regular training	Highest number of sets, advanced versions

In your sessions, "2-4 × 8" means 2 sets (level 1), 3 sets (level 2) or 4 sets (level 3) of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.

Setting the intensity: the effort scale

Score	How it feels	Guide
5-6	Easy to moderate	You could still do 4 to 5 more reps
7-8	Hard but controlled	You have 2 to 3 reps left in reserve
9	Very hard	Only one more rep possible
10	Maximal	To avoid in this program

Under 15 (girls) or 16 (boys)

The program is the same, with a few rules so that the loads stay suited to your age:

- **No heavy sets** of 1 to 5 reps: take a load you could lift 10 to 12 times, and do 6 to 8.
- **Always keep at least 3 reps in reserve:** never a set to failure.
- **Technique before weight:** only add load if the movement stays perfect from the start to the end of the set.
- **The barbell only with an adult** who knows the movement (coach, trainer, trained parent).
- Jumps, sprints and prevention do not change.
- At the gym, every loaded exercise shows its version for your age, under "Under 15 (girls) or 16 (boys)".

Sharp pain, a joint giving way, dizziness: stop the exercise. Discomfort that lasts more than 48 hours or comes back every session must be seen by a health professional.

Your typical week

Each week has **3 sessions (A, B and C)**, plus an optional short **bonus session D**, focused on prevention and mobility.

Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
Session A	Rest or club	Session B	Rest or club	Session D (bonus)	Session C	Rest

This is an example: adapt it to your schedule while following these rules.

- At least **48 hours** between two A, B or C sessions.
- At least **one full rest day** per week.
- No session the day before a friendly match or a very intense team practice.
- A missed session is not made up by doubling up: just carry on with the next session.

How a session works

Step	Duration	What it is for
1. Warm-up	10-12 min	Prepare your body and reduce the risk of injury. The same every session.
2. First block	15-20 min	Your first goal. Explosiveness and Power always come first, when you have all your energy.
3. Second block	15-20 min	Your second goal. If you chose a single goal, this block works it from another angle.
4. Core and prevention	5-8 min	Strengthen the areas most exposed in handball: knees, ankles, shoulders, hamstrings, adductors.
5. Cool-down	5 min	Walking and light stretches.

Why such a thorough warm-up? A large study in 120 Norwegian handball clubs showed that a warm-up working on running, balance and jump landings roughly halved knee and ankle injuries (Olsen et al., BMJ, 2005).

Progression over 8 weeks

Week	Phase	What we are after	Volume	Effort
1	Getting started	Get your body used to effort again, learn the movements	Low	5-6
2	Getting started	Same, a little more work	Low to medium	6
3	Building up	Increase the loads gradually	Medium	7
4	Building up	Keep building	Medium to high	7-8
5	Building up	Heaviest week	High	8
6	Intensity	Less volume, more speed	Medium	7-8
7	Intensity	Maximum quality on every rep	Medium	8
8	Taper	Recover while keeping the intensity	Halved	6-7

Week 8: less is more. You do half the sets, with the same quality, to start the season in top shape.

Tracking your sessions

Log every session: it is the best way to progress and to spot fatigue.

Date	Session	Perceived effort (/10)	How you feel today (/5)	Discomfort or notes

- How you feel at 1 or 2 out of 5 two sessions in a row: ease off (fewer sets) or take an extra rest day.
- Everything is easy (effort at 5 when 7-8 is planned): move up a level.

What next?

At the end of the 8 weeks, the season starts. To keep what you have built without tiring your legs before games, you can follow on with the **first half of the season**: 2 short sessions a week until the Christmas holidays.

A question about the program? Just reply to the email that sent you this document.